

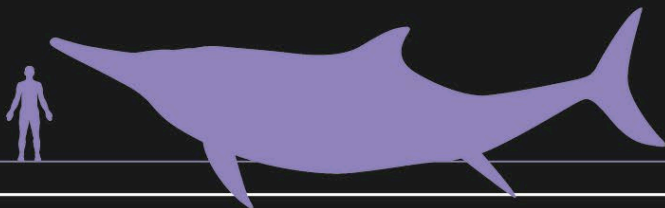
OUTSIZED EYES

TEMNODONTOSAURUS

The top predator of the Early Jurassic seas, *Temnodontosaurus* was a type of large prehistoric marine reptile called an ichthyosaur. Its massive eyes may have helped it see in the dark, murky waters of the oceans, although specimens found in present-day Germany show that some *Temnodontosaurus* appear to have stayed near the water's surface. Along with excellent vision, this creature had large, sharp teeth, which it used to catch a variety of prey. While its diet mainly consisted of fish and other marine creatures, its fossils show that some of the species may have been able to catch and tear apart other marine reptiles, such as plesiosaurs and other ichthyosaurs. In fact, the bones of one unfortunate creature were discovered inside the stomach of a *Temnodontosaurus* fossil.

AT A GLANCE

- **LENGTH** Up to 49 ft (15 m)
- **LIVED** 198–185 MYA
- **DIET** Carnivore
- **HABITAT** Oceans



STATS AND FACTS

Different *Temnodontosaurus* species show varying skull shapes, which may have determined their diet. The long, thin skulls of some were adapted to catching squid and fish, while the short, deep skulls of others would have enabled them to attack larger marine reptiles.

LARGEST EYES



At 10¼ in (26.4 cm) wide, *Temnodontosaurus*'s eyes were even larger than those of modern-day giant squid.

CONICAL TEETH



Temnodontosaurus had conical teeth with ridges down the side, which helped it grip and pierce its prey while underwater.

